



Commentary on 'The case for neuropsychanalysis'

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Dear Editor,

As a psychoanalyst intrigued by the hyphen in the neuro-psychoanalysis I welcomed the discussion for and against ‘The case for neuropsychanalysis’ (2015), but was rather demoralized by the absence of the ‘meeting of the minds’ on two sides of it.

Yovell, Solms and Fotopoulou seemed to do disservice to their case of the usefulness of the neuropsychanalysis by substituting psychological operations (repression) with proposed organic causation of changed brain morphology (of the hippocampus) in their clinical illustration. To psychoanalysts such as Blass and Carmeli (2015) who are skeptical of the conceptual and clinical contribution of the neurosciences to psychoanalysis, this gave cause for renewed opposition, and even alarm.

Something seems amiss. There is probably an existing consensus that each discipline speaks its own language, not translatable into the other because neither the organic nor the psychic realm has equivalence in the other. This, indeed, is what Yovell *et al.* say on p. 1522 in ‘Points of agreement’, namely that: “Psychoanalysis and neurosciences ... employ different methodologies to investigate two complementary aspects of the human mind – the subjective and the objective, neither of which is reducible to the other or more real than the other”.

What then is the lingua franca to bridge the hyphen? Could the Jacksonian view championed in the Yovell *et al.* article provide one? What if instead of saying “two complementary aspects of the human mind” we were to say that the two disciplines represent *two levels of functional organization* of the human mind? Thinking of them as functional organizations, each in its own realm, gives each own autonomy yet also correspondence with the other. That would be in keeping with the Jacksonian spirit of evolutionary hierarchy of strata in functional organizations, referenced in the Yovell *et al.* article. On p. 1516, they write “... the young Freud – influenced by, among others, John Hughlings Jackson – wanted to explain the operations of the brain as governed by hierarchically organized and dynamic neurophysiological function He instead opted for an independent new discipline, in which he would attempt to explain such dynamic organization from the purely functional standpoint, using purely psychological methods of investigation.” This speaks to Freud’s 1888 “moment of transition” (Solms and Saling, 1990). The ‘dynamic organization’ characterization holds true for both neurophysiological and psychological functions.

Although Jacksonian 19th century insights concerned the organization of the central nervous system, the brain (Oppenheimer, 1971), the 21st century neuroscience steps out of the constraints of biological morphology into the virtual realm of functionality, such as that generated by synchronicities of neuronal networks. In Damasio’s (2010) neuroscientific insights, a self, further layered into such functional organizations as

protoself, core self and autobiographical self, makes an entry. Functional organization of culture follows. We are invited to think of human beings in ever-widening concentric spheres of organized functional activity from bodily through psychosociocultural, yet respectful of the integrity of each level's tasks, influences, and constraints. After all, together they carry the responsibility of serving the essential needs of the organism as regulators of its physio – sociocultural homeostasis. The human brain *and* mind both serve as the center for negotiating the integration of the varied inputs from within and without the organism for the sake of arriving at an adaptive coordination. To perform these ongoing living tasks under changing conditions each is necessarily dynamic but also constrained by the delimits of its own organization: of functional morphology in the case of the brain, and of the symbolizing linguistically structured imaginarium it gives rise to – the mind. At the same time they have got to be tethered to one another by some common principles dictated by the imperatives of survival and procreation.

It seems to me that the clinical case of Ms A may serve as a useful example of one such common principle. I would propose that this principle in the presented case could be considered as one of *defense*, that is, protection. The non-inscription of traumatic memories in the hippocampus of patients such as Ms A shares with the psychic mechanism of possible repression of memories a quality of shielding— in the first case of the organic substrate, and in the second, of the 'tissue' of psychic reality. Yes, the media are different, but the governing principle is common.

Damasio, in particular, speaks most eloquently to this idea of biological value carried from a single cell organism to complex cultural organisms of societies in an evolutionary march, with the plastic human brain advancing the amazing subjective versatility of the mind. In the case of Ms A the general biological value of protecting the inner (somatic and well as psychic) milieu can be seen as being served both or either by the hippocampus and the mechanisms of repression. Under the influence of the stress hormones the hippocampus 'protects' the organism's self from depositing traumatizing memories, while Freudian repression does the same by the psychic means at its disposal. Indeed, such conceptualization may find particular receptivity in psychoanalysts who have long been acquainted with the idea that the body serves as a template for the symbolic activity of the mind (Freud, 1900). What goes for the external body may pertain to the interior states and mechanisms as well.

To sum up:

A neuroscientifically informed psychoanalyst may consider that all Ms A's childhood resources had been undoubtedly greatly taxed under the traumatic situation. Without external parental protection, both her psychological (repression) and physiological (hippocampus) responses were likely recruited in an effort to provide that function.

Yet, while so informed, I agree with Blass and Carmeli that such psychoanalyst needs to preserve the conceptual and clinical integrity of her clinical

and theoretical discipline. At the same time, the need to observe its hermeneutic laws ought not consign it to being deprived of conceptual richness offered by judiciously managed insights from the neurosciences. While 'biologistic' applications do disservice to both fields of inquiry, Biology, writ large, enriches each because it encompasses the body *and* the psyche. Indeed one can argue that the care of psychoanalytic rigor is especially important *because* the psyche is deeply implicated in the homeostatic management of the human organism it inhabits. The fact that the same may apply to the neuronal structure such as the hippocampus does not replace it but rather serves to illuminate. This is the essence of the hyphen in neuropsychanalysis: the media on two sides of it are different, but they are bridged by common biological principles engaged in the maintenance of human life and well-being.

Respectfully,

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